

NIGHT WITHOUT END

Fathers and sons, wives and husbands, children and the elderly—Mumbai's 60 hours of horror was the great leveller as it ripped through families, both rich and poor, and led to an outpouring of grief that has still not dried up. Some survivors have been left believing in a second life.

IN THE NAME OF THE SON

SEVANTILAL PAREKH, 78

WHAT HAPPENED: Lost his son Sunil and daughter-in-law Reshma at the Oberoi Hotel

There was a table at the Tiffin Sevantilal Parekh knew that almost belonged to Sunil, his son. The staff at that Oberoi restaurant chatted endlessly to Sunil's wife, the foodie Reshma, over the couple's many meals there. So, why were their phones not reachable on the night of November 26? When Sunil and Reshma surely were 10 minutes away on Marine Drive once again at Tiffin with a friend? Why was there no answer? Where were they?

Sevantilal, and the rest of the family at home, tried. For two days they tried. As the darkness and horror of the events in Mumbai covered the sky over the city and entered the souls of its people, the Parekhs hoped and prayed and tried to reach their young, loved ones. "We tried asking authorities what was going on. There was no answer," Sevantilal says. Today, he is a 78-year-old father who lost a 45-year-old son on the black night of November 26, forced to manage the family's shipping business once again.

The senior Parekh had all but retired after his son

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took over United Shippers Limited in the early 1990s. "I have no ambition, no motivation left. The only reason I'm sitting here is because my son worked very hard for this company," says Sevantilal. The company had just 300 employees when Sunil took over. Today, it has 1,600. Sevantilal says his son was compassionate and sensitive not only towards his family but also with his employees. For Sunil, family came first. He would never stay out of the city for more than a night. Holidays were never planned without his two daughters, Anandita, 13, and Arundhati, 11. It was just three years ago that Sunil had organised a grand celebration for Sevantilal's 75th birthday. Ironically, the function took place at the Oberoi hotel. As a surprise, Sunil had presented his father with a coffee table book he had personally put together. That book, with handwritten letters and old and new photographs of the entire family, today finds pride of place in Sevantilal's office. That and a framed picture of a smiling Sunil. There's even a calendar that has several